

The ground, meaning the earth under our feet, is associated with a number of idioms which refer to positions people occupy in giving arguments and opinions. The ground is also seen as a starting point from which plans, actions, etc. can take off, like a plane.

A

Attitudes, arguments, positions

Agreeing / accepting ideas

We share a lot of **common ground**, so I think we'll work well together. [things we agree on; similar opinions and experience]

The idea that organic food is better for people as well as the environment is **gaining ground**. [becoming more popular/accepted]

Disagreeing/opposing

The Prime Minister's speech has **cut the ground from under the feet of** the Opposition. [made their position weaker by saying something better]

She was determined to **hold/stand her ground** and not to be persuaded by the others. [refuse to change her opinion/behaviour]

I think you're **on dangerous ground** if you try to insist that they change the financial system. [hold a view/opinion that will probably offend/upset people]

Changing your opinion/argument

For a long time, neither side would **give ground**, but now it seems they are ready to consider each other's position. [change their opinion or accept the other side's position]

It's very difficult to argue with Rosa; she keeps **shifting her ground**. [changing her opinion/argument]

B

The ground as starting point

If someone ...	this means they ...
gets a project/idea off the ground (or if a project/idea gets off the ground)	help it start off well/successfully (or it starts well/successfully)
gets in on the ground floor	become involved in something right at the beginning (and which is often successful later)
prepares the ground (for some activity)	create a good/suitable situation for something to take place

C

Other useful *ground* idioms

I felt so embarrassed I just **wished the ground would swallow me up**. [wished I could just disappear]

Good restaurants **are thick/thin on the ground** in this town. [there are a lot / very few]

Living near the airport **suits me down to the ground** since I travel a lot. [suits me perfectly]

As a result of the media attention, she has **gone to ground**. [hidden, not appeared in public]

This part of town was my old **stamping/stomping ground** when I was a student here ten years ago. [place where I spent a lot of time]

Exercises

61.1 Complete these idioms with prepositions.

- The Minister cleverly cut the ground her opponents' feet by announcing new tax cuts.
- He got the ground floor with e-commerce and became a millionaire when it took off.
- Good hotels are thin the ground in the smaller cities; you have to go to the capital to get hotels of international standard.
- The project has got the ground quicker and more smoothly than we expected.
- Part-time work suits me the ground at the moment as I'm trying to study at the same time.



'Well I think it suits you down to the ground.'

61.2 Use the idioms from exercise 61.1 to rewrite these sentences. Make any other necessary changes.

- I'm afraid there aren't many good cafés in the town centre.
- Working from home is perfect for me as I can look after our small child at the same time.
- If you join our company now, I promise you are coming into it at the beginning of some really exciting developments.
- Reducing the price now will enable us to get a big advantage over our competitors, because they will not be able to do the same.
- It's a good idea, but I don't know if it will ever become popular.

61.3 Rewrite each sentence with an idiom which means the opposite of the underlined words.

- She let them persuade her and had a meeting with the boss to tell her everything.
- We have no ideas or experiences we can share, so we need to discuss how we can work together.
- I think you can quite safely raise the subject of longer holidays at the staff meeting.
- There are very few English Language schools in the capital city.
- The idea that public transport is better for the environment is becoming less popular.

61.4 Answer these questions.

- If a famous person goes to ground, what do they do?
- How do you feel if you wish the ground would swallow you up?
- If someone refuses to give ground, what do they refuse to do?
- Which idiom in this unit means changing your position in an argument?
- One idiom in this unit gives you a choice between *stamping* and *stomping*. What is it and what does it mean?
- If you want to sell a new product in a new country and someone has prepared the ground for you, what does that mean?